

CUTTING DOWN: Per capita consumption of pulses has declined



act," says Kamath.

Significantly, 50 per cent of the companies participating in FICCI's latest Business Confidence Survey have reported that overall economic conditions have deteriorated over the last six months compared with 19 per cent in the last survey.

While austerity for the Government may be self-imposed, it is a by-product of inflation for industry. The Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers, for instance, feels the hike in excise duty on big cars like SUVs will only hit the growth of the manufacturing sector which has been a performer in terms of pushing consumption and growth. "This industry is already going through a downturn due to high input costs," says Senior Director Sugato Sen.

The future is foreboding. And not just for fuel prices. The price rise has already moved beyond commodities and fine decimal points to FMCG goods, making prices of biscuits, soaps, shampoos and detergents costlier by 10-30 per cent. Companies are talking about a further 10 per cent increase in the next few months.

The common man with fewer options is hit the hardest. Analysts say household budgets would rise by 8-10 per cent and the Ministry of Statistics

DHIMAN MAJUMDAR MARKETING EXECUTIVE AT A MEDIA HOUSE IN KOLKATA

FAMILY INCOME: Rs 7 lakh per annum

TRAVEL: Holiday travel has been hit as he and his family are planning to skip a vacation

LIFESTYLE: The monthly cost for food is around Rs 15,000 while on other daily necessities, the bill comes to Rs 10,000 per month. Rising expenses have postponed plans to upgrade from a two-wheeler to a car and shopping sprees are on hold.

FUEL: Spends around Rs 1,500 a month on fuel for the family two-wheeler

SAVINGS: The annual savings plan of the family is around Rs 50,000

"We cannot compromise on something as basic as food even though it has become so expensive. We would rather sacrifice on travelling and eating out."

by Elora Sen

SUVASHIS MULLICK



Dhiman (second from left)